

As we storm TFT shores are we really aware of what's good or are we just grasping straws? Here's some graphic advice to a flatter computing experience...34 Display Mates in our labs!

Michael Browne

If seeing is really believing, there has been sharp appreciation in the performance of LCD's since our last test way back in April last year, and this trend will continue over the next few years as manufacturers are constantly innovating flat panel technology. Then there's the binary of declining prices. Sounds too good to be true, doesn't it?

Consider this—a 19-inch LCD cost approximately Rs 25,000 last year, and sported a typical response time of 12 ms. Today, a 19-inch widescreen LCD will cost you around Rs 14,000, and sport a response time of 4 ms or thereabouts.

Domestic India has gotten onto the flat wave, and an increasing number of people have been replacing CRTs with LCDs. OEM PC manufacturers like HP, Dell, LG and Acer have been offering LCDs with their PC's for some time now. The latest craze to emerge in 2006, and continue this year, is widescreen monitors. Widescreen LCDs (with an aspect ratio of 16:10) have come out of the blue, priced lower than regular 4:3 LCDs, thanks to lower production costs. The reason for their quick adoption besides the attractive pricing is the growing adoption of multimedia PCs for movies and 3D games—all of which benefit from widescreens. DVDs and all HD sources, as you know, are typically wide aspect ratio sources, and viewing them on a widescreen monitor translates to a greater viewing area and smaller ugly black strips on the top and bottom of your screen.

Another trend we've noticed is the growing affection for larger panels—which is of course a function of their steadily declining prices. The proverbial hot cakes (15-inches) have lost much of their fan following, and the entry level purchase has become a 17-inch LCD. The 19-inch category is sought after by enthusiasts and those heavily into Web browsing and multimedia; the 20.1-inch and above category is a favourite among demanding gamers and enthusiasts with fatter wallets.

Market trends generally reflect in our tests, which is why we received no 15-inch LCDs. What we did get was a bevy of 17- and 19-inch monitors—14 and 15 respectively. In smaller numbers were the bigger boys—the 20.1-inch (one from ASUS), 22-inch (three models) and one humongous 24-inch from BenQ. That's right—we got LCDs that are bigger than traditional TV's!

19-INCH LCDS

Fluctuations were at their wildest with prices ranging from as low as Rs 11,300 (the Intex 1904w), to a wallet-busting 35,000 (the NEC MultiSync 1990FX). As expected, specifications were quite close to each other (at least on paper), though there were quite a few additional features here and there.